pressure. The speculation about his death being murder by strangulation and/or poisoning by some sort of underworld betting mafia. The connections drawn to us, wrongly, of course. In my twenty years as a cricketer, it was the toughest time for us as a team. We couldn't even sleep. I remember, we all had single rooms but none of us felt like sleeping alone. We were scared. The night of Bob's death, we all teamed up in twos and threes in our rooms to feel safe. Even the skipper, Inzi, shared a room, with Mushtaq Ahmed, then part of the coaching staff. Think about that – a strong, solid man like Inzamam-ul-Haq, reduced to the fear of being alone. I don't think I ever saw him face a tougher time as a captain. It depresses me even to think about it today. We never really got over it. I know I didn't. Yes, things got better when we got home. But I hated it. All of it.

After Bob's demise, the PCB announced a slew of measures to restructure the team. It formed a bunch of committees. There was a call for a new era and a rebuilding of the team. Inzi lost his captaincy. Shoaib Malik was appointed the new captain, a decision that came with its own bunch of problems.

At twenty-five, Shoaib wasn't fit to lead Pakistan. Conceptually, it was a good decision, but the PCB messed up in several ways. First, they got me involved, asking me if I wanted to be vice-captain. That post eventually went to Salman Butt anyway, and as the records show, the PCB's disregard for seniority would chafe many of us. Second, Malik's captaincy made the fissures within the team even wider as 'groupism' and dressing-room politics became rampant. The 'senior-versus-junior' tussle that began in 2002–3 eventually went over the top. As a result, we didn't end up winning any major tournaments. Worse was the combination of leadership: Malik was barely an acceptable captain to the side, while Butt wasn't tolerable at all. To be sure, most of us couldn't accept him as vice-captain; I certainly did not. Moreover, Butt's subsequent promotion and tenure as captain was an infamous one. (More on that in the pages to come.)

And then came the bounce back. Or an attempt at one.

After Bob's demise, our next ODI series was in Abu Dhabi against Sri Lanka in May 2007. It was a case in point of Pakistan's sheer grit against all odds.

In the first ODI game, chasing 236, we were struggling at 137 for 5. We still needed 99 runs, with 18 overs to go. There was enough time. But there weren't enough men.

I came in at number seven and Kamran Akmal was at the other end. Thanks to our partnership, we were home in 11 overs. I got 73 from just 34 (8x4, 4x6) and was especially kind to Malinga Bandara, sending him reeling for 32 runs from his last over. What helped was that we were playing in Abu Dhabi; it almost felt like playing at home. The crowd is made up of a majority of Pakistan supporters, mostly Pathans. I got four straight sixes in. Bob Woolmer was gone but his words were still with me – 'Always be yourself' – and my A-game was back on.

The cricket was interesting – a hallmark of Pakistan's version of the game. We were in a corner and had to make a comeback. We were under pressure. We were angry; hell, I was seething. The two-match ban didn't help. But my knock did. Also, it was Inzi's last match. All of what was happening around us was so negative and unpromising. So yeah, in that lone victory against the Lankans, we bounced back, mentally at least.

The tournament would continue on the same pace. We sealed that first match and then I helped Shoaib captain the side to victory through the second game – we were defending 313 on board – as I picked up three wickets.